

On the Pasture

The next morning, Heidi woke to a loud whistle. When she opened her eyes, her little bed and the hay around her was glowing in golden sunlight. At first, she was a bit confused about where she was. But then she heard Grandfather's deep voice outside. She suddenly remembered everything from the day before. She recalled her journey up the mountain and all the people she'd left behind in the village.

While living in the village, Heidi had not gotten a chance to play outside much. This often made her sad. She was delighted now to be waking up in her new home where she could go outside and visit the goats.

Heidi jumped out of bed and got dressed. She went quickly down the ladder and ran outside. Peter was already there with his goats. He was waiting for Schwänli and Bärli, Grandfather's goats.

"Do you want to go with him to the pasture?" Grandfather asked.

Heidi excitedly clapped her hands and said, "Yes!"



"Go wash yourself first before you go. The sun will laugh at you if he sees how dirty you are," Grandfather joked. He pointed to a big tub of water in the sunlight. Heidi quickly washed up until her cheeks turned pink.

While she was doing that, Grandfather told Peter to come inside and bring his lunch bag. Peter followed him inside, and Grandfather put some extra bread and cheese in Peter's bag. He made sure there was enough for both Peter and Heidi. He also added a little bowl and said, "Heidi doesn't know how to drink straight from a goat like you do. She'll stay with you all day, so make sure to milk two bowls full for her."

Heidi and Grandfather were talking after she had washed up. She had rubbed her skin so hard with a rough towel that she turned red like a lobster. Heidi asked Grandfather if the sun would still laugh at her, and he said no. But he reminded her to wash well again after playing outside all day.

Heidi and Peter started walking happily up the mountain. The sky was clear and blue, and the sunshine made everything bright. Heidi was very happy and kept running around. There were beautiful flowers everywhere. Heidi saw red primroses, blue gentians, and golden rock roses. She was so excited that she ran ahead of Peter and the goats. She picked bunches of flowers to take home.

Peter tried to keep an eye on her, but it was difficult because Heidi kept running here and there. She was fascinated by the flowers. He had to keep the goats together and look for Heidi at the same time, which frustrated him.



At one point, he couldn't find her and called out. Heidi was behind a little hill, surrounded by sweet-smelling flowers. Peter told her to be careful of the cliff edge, and Heidi asked innocently, "What cliff?" She had been lost in the beauty of the flowers and had not even realized how far she had wandered.

Heidi and Peter had a long journey ahead. Heidi hurried to Peter, her apron filled with flowers. Peter told her, "You have enough flowers now. If you pick them all today, there won't be any tomorrow." Heidi agreed because her apron was already full.

Together, they walked up the mountain. They followed the goats who were eager to find herbs. Peter picked a spot at the base of a tall cliff. It was a dangerous place with rocks hanging over one side, so it was good that Grandfather had warned them.

When they reached the spot, Peter put his bag in a safe place so the wind wouldn't blow it away. Then he lay down in the grass to rest. Heidi took off her apron and rolled it up. She placed it next to Peter's bag and sat down next to him.

From where she sat, Heidi could see the shiny valley below and a big snowy mountain in the distance. She was so peaceful and happy, enjoying the mountains around her and feeling the gentle breeze.

Suddenly, a loud screech broke the silence. Heidi looked up and saw a huge eagle soaring above her. Its wings spread wide as it circled overhead. "Wake up, Peter!" Heidi called, excited. "Look, the eagle!"



Heidi and Peter picnic on the mountainside



Peter woke up. They both watched as the eagle flew higher and higher until it vanished behind the mountain. “Where did it go?” Heidi wondered.

“Home to its nest,” said Peter, still watching the sky.

“Oh, does it really live way up there? How wonderful that must be! But tell me why it screams so loud?” Heidi inquired.

“Because it has to, that’s just how it is,” Peter replied.

Heidi really wanted to climb up and see where the bird lived. But Peter quickly said, “Oh no, it’s too high up! Even goats can’t climb up there. Grandfather told me to make sure you’re safe, so no.” Peter started calling and whistling for the goats, and soon they were all together in the field. Heidi was happy running around with them, watching them play.

Meanwhile, Peter got lunch ready. He put Heidi’s big pieces of food on one side and his smaller ones on the other side. Then he milked Bärli and put the fresh milk in a bowl for them to share. When everything was ready, he called Heidi to come and eat. “Come and sit down. Your lunch is all set,” Peter told her.

“Is this milk for me?” Heidi asked.

Peter nodded, “Yes, you drink first. I’ll get some more after you.”

Heidi wondered, “Where do you get your milk?”

Peter pointed, “From my own goat, the speckled one over there. Now go on and eat!”

Heidi started eating. When she finished the milk, Peter filled her bowl again. She broke off a piece of bread and

gave the bigger remaining piece to Peter. She even handed him all her cheese, saying, “You can have this. I’m full!” Peter was amazed because he would never think of sharing his portion like that. At first, he didn’t believe Heidi was serious. But then she placed the food right in front of him. Realizing she meant it, Peter happily started eating. He thanked Heidi with a nod.

While Peter enjoyed his meal, Heidi watched the goats and started to ask Peter more about them.

The boy told Heidi each of the goats’ names. She paid close attention so she could remember them later. One goat, called Big Turk, liked to push the others around with his big horns. Most goats stayed away from him. But another goat named Thistlefinch was brave and fought back.

A small, white goat named Snowhopper was always crying. Heidi felt bad for her and hugged her, asking why she was so sad. Peter explained that her mother had been sold to someone far away in Maienfeld two days ago. Snowhopper had no grandmother or grandfather.

Heidi comforted Snowhopper. She promised to visit her every day and help her if she needed anything. Snowhopper stopped crying and snuggled against Heidi.

Heidi also noticed that Schwänli and Bärli were especially clean and pretty. They stayed away from Big Turk and found the best bushes to eat from. Heidi pointed this out to Peter. He said it was because Grandfather took good care of them. He washed them often and gave them salt. He also had the best stable for them.



Suddenly Peter jumped up and ran after the goats. Heidi followed him quickly because she knew something was wrong. Peter had seen Thistlefinch walking too close to a very dangerous cliff. He got there just in time to stop the goat from falling off the edge!

Unfortunately, Peter tripped on a stone and could only grab the goat by one leg. Thistlefinch was upset and bleated loudly. Since Peter couldn't get up, he called for help. Heidi saw that Peter was nearly pulling the goat's leg off. She quickly picked some sweet-smelling herbs and held them under the goat's nose. She said gently, "Come on, Thistlefinch, be sensible. You might fall and hurt yourself."

Thistlefinch settled down and ate the herbs from Heidi's hand. When Peter stood up, he and Heidi led the goat back to safety. Peter was so upset that he raised his stick to punish the goat. The goat looked scared and backed away. Heidi yelled, "Peter, no, don't hit him! Look how scared he is!"

Peter grumbled back, "He deserves it!" He was ready to strike the poor animal.

But Heidi grabbed his arm and insisted, "You can't hurt him! Let him go!"

Seeing Heidi so determined, Peter finally gave up and dropped his stick. "I'll let him go if you give me some of your cheese tomorrow."

Heidi promised, "You can have all my cheese tomorrow and every day. I don't need it. I'll also give you a big piece of bread if you promise never to beat the goats."

Peter muttered, "I don't care." And that's how he prom-



Peter raises his stick to punish the goats



ised not to hurt the goats ever again.

So, after a dramatic day, the sun began to set on the peaceful mountains. Heidi sat on the grass behind the mountains. She watched the bluebells and wild roses glowing in the sunset. The mountaintops began to light up too. Heidi excitedly called to Peter, “Look, the mountains and sky look like they’re on fire! Even the moon seems to be burning. See how the snow is sparkling? It looks like the eagle’s nest and the fir trees are on fire too!”

Peter was quietly peeling his walking stick. He looked up calmly and replied, “That isn’t a fire. It always looks like this.”

Perplexed, Heidi asked, “But what is it then?”

Peter explained simply, “It just happens by itself.”

Heidi continued to observe in wonder. “Look, everything is turning pink now! And that mountain with snow and sharp peaks—what is it called?”

Peter answered matter-of-factly, “Mountains don’t have names.”

The vibrant colors began to fade, and Heidi sighed, “Oh no, the fire is going out. What a shame!”

“Don’t worry,” Peter reassured her. “It will look like this again tomorrow.”

As they gathered the goats to head home, Heidi asked about the next day. She hoped to see the beautiful colors again. Peter confirmed it would be the same, which cheered Heidi up. They walked back to the hut where Heidi’s grandfather was waiting. Heidi excitedly ran to him, followed by the



goats.

Peter said goodbye for the evening, inviting Heidi to come with him again the next day. Heidi happily agreed. She gave a final hug to her favorite goat, Snowhopper, before Peter left. She was already looking forward to another beautiful sunset.

Heidi ran back to Grandfather, beaming with joy. “Oh, Grandfather! It was so beautiful out there! I saw a fire and roses glowing on the rocks! And look at all the flowers I brought for you!” She excitedly emptied her apron to show him.

But the flowers didn’t look so cheerful anymore. They were wilted and sad. Heidi was confused. “What happened to them, Grandfather? They looked so different outside!”

“They’re meant to stay in the sun, not be tucked away in an apron,” Grandfather explained.

“Then I won’t pick them anymore! But, Grandfather, why does the eagle cry so loudly?” Heidi asked, curious.

“Go wash up, and I’ll get your milk ready. We can talk more at dinner,” Grandfather suggested.

After cleaning up, Heidi sat at the dinner table with her milk and asked again about the eagle.

“The eagle is laughing at the people in the villages below,” Grandfather responded. He imitated the eagle’s loud call. “He’s telling them they would be happier if they lived up high like him, away from all the arguing.”

Heidi nodded, thinking about the carefree eagle. Then another question popped into her head. “Why don’t the



mountains have names, Grandfather?”

“They all have names,” he assured her. “Tell me how they look, and I can name each one for you.”

Heidi described the mountains she saw, and Grandfather knew all their names. She then shared everything about her day, especially the magical fire she saw.

“That’s the sun saying goodnight to the mountains,” he explained. “He sends his prettiest light so they won’t forget him until he comes back in the morning.”

Heidi loved this idea and looked forward to seeing the sun’s goodnight kiss again.

Soon, it was bedtime, and Heidi drifted off to sleep. She dreamed of little Snowhopper jumping happily along on the glowing mountainside. Many beautiful roses bloomed all around her.



A huge eagle soars overhead

